

THE UNIVERSAL HOUSE OF JUSTICE

1998-08-12

To an individual believer

1 dear bahá'í friend,
2 . . . elaborating your previously expressed views concerning your feeling of a
3 need for bahá'í sacred literature in simplified english, and we are to convey
4 the following.
5 The house of justice fully appreciates that the real purpose of your letters
6 is to find a way to help the largest number of people, whatever their ability
7 in english, to experience the word of god as brought by bahá'u'lláh; and it
8 sympathizes with your desire to make the Teachings accessible to those who are not
adept at reading english. undoubtedly, a great deal can be done to
9 fulfill your desire; however, it is important for you to understand basically
10 that the standard of presentation of the divine word cannot be lowered,
11 and that it must be made available to all, including those who cannot read
12 it in its elevated style. No simplification of language can take its place.
13 even an unlettered person is capable of responding to the exalted lan-
14 guage of the holy Scriptures, as it is the inner spirit of the divine Texts
15 that touches the heart. bahá'u'lláh states in a well-known Tablet that, "The
16 word of god is the king of words and its pervasive influence is incalculable.
17 . . . The word is the master key for the whole world, inasmuch as through
18 its potency the doors of the hearts of men, which in reality are the doors of heaven,
are unlocked."
19 281-1 hearts become attracted and souls confirmed
20 through the mysterious effects of exposure to the living word—that word
21 which has demonstrated the power to stimulate intellectual development. you
yourself have mentioned that a mystical experience enabled you to per-
22 severe in learning to understand the divine Texts.
23 you write that the people who you are trying to reach are not well educat-

24 ed and thus not able to comprehend the language of the writings. it is not
25 the prerogative of anyone to judge what another individual is capable of
un-derstanding from the word of god. consider, for instance, that throughout

26 281-1. Tb, p. 173.281.1

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282 1996–2000 • T h e f o u r Y e a r P l a n

283 61the world millions of christians, from all walks of life, have for generations
284 derived spiritual sustenance from the king james bible. The publication
285 of the bible in simplified english is a relatively recent development and
286 coincides with a period in which christian organizations have lost much of
287 their historical vitality; it also coincides with the lamentable decline in the
288 standard of english usage in the united States and other english-speaking
289 countries. An even more potent example relates to islám, many generations
290 of the adherents of which, literate or illiterate, have memorized all or large portions of
their holy book, the qur'án; it would be unthinkable to such
291 believers to be presented with the proposition of simplifying the language
292 of m uḡammad's r evelation.

293 The house of justice does not want to see a dilution of the standard of
294 english translation of the writings established by Shoghi effendi. regard-
295 ing such translations, it is suggested that you may find it illuminating to
296 read the two paragraphs in the introduction to the kitáb-i-Aqdas . . . con-
297 cerning “the style of language in which the kitáb-i-Aqdas has been rendered
into e nglish.”

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The matter of englishing certain Arabic or persian terminologies has

299 been and will continue to be given attention by the house of justice. for
300 instance, it has already decided that terms and place names, like Teheran and Shiraz,
which have recognized spellings in languages using the roman
301 alphabet, need not appear in their transliterated forms as øihrán and Shíráz
302 in materials intended for general distribution among non-b ahá'ís.

303 it is of course understood that some people do not have the vocabulary to
304 read literature of a certain level. it is possible, therefore, to accompany the
305 Texts with explanatory material. if, in this context, you wish to pursue your
306 question further, you will have to take it up with your National Spiritual
307 Assembly and abide by its advice.
308 As you strive to deepen your knowledge of the faith and to serve its vital
309 interests, be assured of the ardent prayers of the house of justice in the
310 holy Shrines that you may be divinely assisted and confirmed.
311 with loving bahá'í greetings,

for Department of the Secretariat

312 281-2. kA, p. 10.281.5

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282 Messages from The Universal House of Justice

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Release of a Compilation on the Arts

[signed: The Universal House of Justice]